

In this section, you'll learn some of the command line's general concepts and common commands. You could master a large number of cryptic commands to become a real sorcerer, but you only need to know about a dozen or so to solve most problems. The exact command names might vary slightly on different operating systems, but the underlying concepts are the same.

Opening a Terminal Window

To open a terminal window, do the following:

- On Windows, click the Start button, type **Command Prompt**, and then press ENTER.
- On macOS, click the **spotlight** icon in the upper-right corner, type **Terminal**, and then press ENTER.
- On Ubuntu Linux, press the WIN key to bring up Dash, type **terminal**, and press ENTER. Alternatively, use the keyboard shortcut CTRL-ALT-T.

Like the interactive shell, which displays a `>>>` prompt, the terminal displays a *shell prompt* at which you can enter commands. On Windows, the prompt will be the full path to the current folder you are in:

```
C:\Users\Al>your commands go here
```

On macOS, the prompt shows your computer's name, a colon, and the cwd with your home folder represented as a tilde (~). After this is your username followed by a dollar sign (\$):

```
Als-MacBook-Pro:~ al$ your commands go here
```

On Ubuntu Linux, the prompt is similar to the macOS prompt except it begins with the username and an at (@) symbol:

```
al@al-VirtualBox:~$ your commands go here
```
